



ARE YOU FOND OF MEAT?

LE BOUCHER / 1970

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Thriller

DIRECTOR
Claude Chabrol

WRITER
Claude Chabrol

STARS
**Jean Yanne,
Stéphane Audran**

BEFORE

1943 Alfred Hitchcock's *Shadow of a Doubt* tells the story of a young girl who discovers a terrible secret.

1968 Chabrol's *Les Biches* stars Stéphane Audran and Jacqueline Sassard as two women who form a lesbian relationship before both falling for the same man.

AFTER

1970 Chabrol's next movie, *La Rupture*, features Audran as a woman whose husband's family is hatching a deadly plot against her.



In French director Claude Chabrol's thriller *Le Boucher* (*The Butcher*), the stark title immediately raises expectations of brutality and gore. Played by the curiously sympathetic Jean Yanne, the Butcher is Popaul, a veteran of the French colonial wars of the 1950s in Indochina and Algeria, who works at a butcher shop in a rural town. At a friend's wedding, Popaul meets Hélène (Stéphane Audran), who becomes strangely fond of him. Popaul is open and sensitive about his past, talking of an abusive father and the cruelty of battle.

When a woman is killed in the forest, however, Hélène begins to think of Popaul a little differently,

Hélène (Stéphane Audran) first meets Popaul (Jean Yanne, on her left) at a wedding. They strike up a close relationship, but it remains platonic despite his clumsy efforts to woo her.

not least because the woman has been stabbed to death with knives, the tools of his trade. And when a second body is found, discovered by one of her own pupils during an idyllic picnic, Hélène finds a lighter that she herself gave Popaul as a present. But instead of handing it to the police, Hélène keeps it, and she is relieved when, later on, Popaul lights one of his many Gauloises with what appears to be the original lighter.